

Definition and Characteristics Of Dyslexia

“Dyslexia is a specific learning disability that is neurological in origin. It is characterised by difficulties with accurate and/or fluent word recognition and by poor spelling and decoding abilities. These difficulties typically result from a deficit in the phonological component of language that is often unexpected in relation to other cognitive abilities and the provision of effective classroom instruction. Secondary consequences may include problems in reading comprehension and reduced reading experience that can impede vocabulary growth and background knowledge.” Adopted by the International Dyslexia Association Board of Directors, November 2002.

General:

- Disability is not due to visual and hearing impairments
- Disability is not due to social-emotional disorders or to socio-cultural deprivation
- There is a long history of dyslexia or learning disability in the family (genetic components)
- Life-long condition – there is no cure. Children do not outgrow their dyslexia.
- Difficulty in processing the written language
- Phonological and / or orthographic processing deficits
- May also have:
 - Weak auditory short term or working memory
 - Sequencing problems – following directions, math steps, keyboarding, hand directions issues (left/right orientation, up/down. East/west, etc.) – surfaces in math/writing
 - Time concepts and time management/organization problems

Common Traits

Reading	• Reversals b/d, “bad for dad” • Rotations p/b, m/w, n/u “me” for “we” • Transpositions “saw” for “was” “from” for “form” • Deletes, changes or adds suffixes in words • Slow labored oral reading of words in isolation with numerous errors. - o Substitution of similar looking words – “house” for “horse”. - o Omits words – common omissions of small words such as <i>a, an, the, to, are.</i> - o Inserts words. • Oral reading is not fluent (slow rate with inaccurate decoding and little expression; does not pay attention to punctuation marks) • Child/adult becomes easily tired after reading for a short time • Reading comprehension is low due to weak decoding; listening comprehension is often higher than reading comprehension.
Spelling	• Reverses, transposes and rotates letters • Deletes and adds letters “plat” for “plant” • Visual memory does not assist “kut” for “cut” “kook” for “cook” • Persistent misspellings of common non-phonetic words such as “they” or “was” • Spelling errors occur when copying from the board or a book
Handwriting	• Writing is slow and labored • Unusual or tight pencil grip • Letter formations are poor; child evidences unusual beginning and ending points • Poor alignment of letters • Variable slant and carriage spacing between letters • Words are pushed together or widely spaced

Written Expression	• Writing is slow and labored • Many spelling errors despite proof reading • Quantity is restricted – tends to write short sentences / paragraphs • Child may have creative ideas but not reflected in writings – improvement noted when using computer and spell check • Tends to use words that they know how to spell • Dysgraphia – handwriting and other issues (putting thoughts on paper, paragraphing skills, sentence, structure, grammar, punctuation, capitalizing, etc.)
Maths	• Difficulty solving word problems • Difficulty in mastering maths facts • Poor number formations, process confusion, misaligned numbers, number reversals, and errors in number sequencing
Social	• Low self esteem • Low frustration tolerance • interpreting nonverbal cues • Making and keeping friends • Misses subtleties of jokes, puns, etc. • Social judgment • Weak problem solving/coping skills • Difficulty in accepting changes in routine
Speech and Language	• Articulation issues • Word retrieval problems

Possible Strengths

- Artistic ability
- Mechanical aptitude
- Global thinker
- Perceptive, empathetic, compassionate
- Musical ability
- Vivid imagination
- Intuition
- Advanced language
- Flair for performing arts
- 3D visual- spatial skills
- Creativity
- Curiosity / tenacity
- Advanced social skills
- Math conceptualization skills

Distinguished Dyslexics

Athletics	Nolan Ryan – baseball
	Greg Louganis – gold medalist Olympic diver
	Magic Johnson – basketball
	Russell White – football player
	Jackie Stewart – race car driver
	Carl Lewis – Olympic gold medalist, track and field
	Pete Rose – baseball
Business	Terry Bradshaw – football
	Rulon Gardner – gold medalist, wrestling Greco-Roman
	Henry Ford, Charles Swab, Pail Orfoles (founder of Kinkos), Thomas Watson, Jr. (CEO IBM), Lewis Presto (Chairman Morgan Guarantee), Delos R Smith (economist), Tommy Hilfiger (designer), William Hewlett (Hewlett Packard), David Murdoch (CEO Dole foods), Richard Branson (Virgin Airlines), Donald Winkler (CEO Ford Motor Company), John Chambers (CISCO Systems), Walt Disney
	Winston Churchill, Woodrow Wilson, John F Kennedy, Nelson Rockefeller, Robert F Kennedy, Prince Charles, Benjamin Franklin.
Performing Arts,	George Burns, Tracey Gold, Steven Cannell, Edward James Olmos, Danny Glover, Dustin Hoffman, Whoopi Goldberg, Cher, Henry Winkler, Tom Cruise, Steven Spielberg, Jack Nicholson, Harry Belafonte, John Lennon,

Comedian,	Rom Smothers, Fanny Flagg, Susan Hampshire, Jay Leno, Robert Blake,
Singer	Anne Bancroft, Dom Delouise, Quentin Tarantino.
Arts	Michelangelo, Augustin Rodin, Leonardo Da Vinci, Malcolm Alexander, Rober Rauschenberg, Charles Schulz (Peanuts), Pablo Picasso, Vincent Van Gough
Literary	Agatha Christie, Jules Verne, Mark Twain, John Irving, F. Scott Fitzgerald, Hans Christian Anderson, Lewis Carrol. Robert Lowell (poet), William Butler Yeats, Edgar Alan Poe, William James (philosopher)
Military	Napoleon Bonaparte, Dwight D Eisenhower, General George Patton, General Westmoreland
Scientists	Albert Einstein, Michael Faraday (physicist), Larry Silver (psychiatrist/author). Thomas Edison, Harvey Cushing (physician / brain surgeon), Edward Hallowell, Galileo, Alexander Graham Bell, Wright Brothers, Henry Ford
Aussies	Jessica Watson – the 2010 Australian Geographic’s Young Adventurer of the Year, round the world solo sailor Alex Edmonson – Olympic Cyclist Jackie French – Author and Snr Australian of the year in 2015 Dick Smith – Entrepreneur, business owner and adventurer, and 1986 Australian of the year

Statistics

- Dyslexia is the most common of all Specific Learning Disorders
- 50% of students in special education have Specific Learning Disorders
- 75-80% of special education students with Specific Learning Disorders have their basic deficit in language and reading
- Dyslexia is the leading cause of reading failure and school dropouts
- Reading failure is the most commonly shared characteristic of juvenile justice offenders
- 50% of juvenile delinquents tested were found to have learning disabilities
- 60% of adults in treatment for substance abuse have learning disabilities
- 60% of adults with severe literacy problems have undetected learning disabilities
- 62% of students with learning disability were unemployed one year after graduation
- Of children evidencing reading problems in 1st grade, 74% will be poor readers in 9th grade
- Dyslexia and ADD frequently co-exist
- Dyslexia occurs in boys and girls at the same rate